

« Ashwin effectively harnessed his cricketing intelligence and relentless hunger for success »

Pragyan Ojha

When we began playing age-group cricket more than two decades ago, I distinctly remember hearing the name Ravichandran Ashwin for the first time. While I represented Hyderabad, Ashwin, back then, was a top-order batter for Tamil Nadu. In one of the Vijay Merchant Trophy Under-17 fixtures, he opened the innings for his team, hammered us all over the park in Visakhapatnam, and went on to score 212 as an opener.

At that time, we recognised Ashwin as a highly skilled batter who could also bowl a bit of off-spin. That perception persisted for at least the next couple of years. As we progressed through the ranks, we heard that Ashwin was consistently claiming wickets at the domestic level and was beginning to be regarded as a specialist spinner.

Eventually, he earned his place in Tamil Nadu's Ranji Trophy team, featured in the Indian Premier League, and established himself as a genuine spinner, breaking into India's white-ball team in 2010.

A year later, when he made his Test debut against West Indies, it coincided with my comeback series.

I remember him coming into my room, where we discussed how to handle the pressures of Test cricket. He sought my suggestions on certain aspects, and having known each other for years, it was heartening to see how far Ashwin had

come. That marked the beginning of our partnership for India.

Looking back at his career, it is remarkable to see his journey.

Transforming from a batter into one of the legends of Indian cricket is an extraordinary feat. I believe he has effectively harnessed his cricketing intelligence and relentless hunger for success. Even in challenging situations, Ashwin has adapted to the ever-changing landscape of international cricket, and that adaptability has been key to his success.

If you consider it, cricket has evolved significantly since 2010. To excel, players had to embrace a degree of unorthodoxy in their approach, and Ashwin has never shied away from stepping out of his comfort zone.

This combination of cricketing intelligence and an insatiable drive to perform has enabled him to claim 537 wickets in Test cricket, which is phenomenal.

There is a fine line between being open to new ideas and selectively incorporating what enhances your skillset. In such scenarios, cricketing intelligence plays a pivotal role. Ashwin has excelled in picking up elements that add value to his game, and in doing so, he has become an inspiration for the younger generation.

As told to Shayan Acharya



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR